and the US] started it. They martyred our leader, military commanders and scientists. They martyred innocent students at school and bombarded our infrastructure. We simply defended ourselves. Regarding Chabahar, Iran sits at a crossroads of regional connectivity. This is the easiest, most economical route for regional countries to build economic, cultural, political, scientific and social ties. We are ready to revive this route again.

Q. How viable is Iran for investors, including Indian businesses, given that you're facing US sanctions?
The US has begun sanctioning any country it wishes and the intention of BRICS is to break this totalitarianism. BRICS was developed to change the nature of our interactions, trade and cooperation. We are here to try to move the world away from American unilateralism.

Q. Where does Iran stand six months into the confrontation? Are you weaker or stronger militarily, economically, strategically?
All countries have problems. But what the US did made us more united.

"DONALD TRUMP SAYS SOMETHING DIFFERENT EVERY DAY. ONE DAY HE WANTS TO DESTROY IRAN; ANOTHER DAY, HE SAYS HE IS A FRIEND OF IRAN"

Q. Are you seeking nuclear weapons? Is nuclear enrichment non-negotiable for Iran?
This is US propaganda. We are a member of the NPT (Non-Proliferation Treaty); they carry out the greatest amount of monitoring of our nuclear activities. We have worked within the framework of international principles. If we were seeking nuclear weapons, we would not have become an NPT member. What substantiated evidence have they found that allows them to attack us? It is all lies.

Q. Then what is the purpose of Israel claiming for years that Iran possesses nuclear weapons or is on the path to acquiring them?
Israel is not a member of the NPT and has nuclear weapons on a massive scale. Is any international institution protesting why they have them? In Gaza and Lebanon, they have killed over 70,000 people. They have blockaded routes for water and food and everything else. The world sees this, but why does no one say anything to Israel?

"ISRAEL IS NOT A MEMBER OF THE NPT AND HAS NUCLEAR WEAPONS ON A MASSIVE SCALE. IS ANY INTERNATIONAL INSTITUTION PROTESTING WHY THEY HAVE THEM?"

They attacked our country unprovoked. They imagined that, just as in Venezuela, they would conquer our country within 24 hours. Not only did this not happen, but our people have taken to the streets and our military has sacrificed themselves to stand up to the enemy. Because of this, the government has been able to resolve its problems. Even those who were somewhat discontented insist on Iran's territorial integrity.

Q. What is the status of the Iran-US conflict. Is there a halt? Why are the ceasefires and negotiations failing?
When they launched the war, we were at the negotiating table. Afterward, we returned to the table again. We were about to reach a final agreement when they attacked us again. Again, we had some dialogue. After all these savage attacks, we reached a kind of understanding and signed a memorandum of understanding, but then they tore it up. How can we start negotiating and be sure they will honour their commitments?

Q. President Trump continues to say he's talking to the "real leaders" of Iran, not this government. Who are these new leaders?
I think you have to ask him. He says something different every day. One day he wants to destroy Iran; another day he says he is a friend of Iran.

Q. Talks with the US went on, with Pakistan mediating, and there was an MoU. Has Pakistan-mediated negotiation failed? Was Oman a better negotiator?
Pakistan is a friendly neighbouring country, and it made a lot of effort so that we could establish peace. Qatar was also helping with the same MoU. I don't know what the problem was, because they (the US) want us to renegotiate. The main issue was that America should end its sanctions and open up the routes. We are ready to act within the framework of internationally recognised principles. They say we have to change these positions and talk about something else. But no, we said what we said. What else is there to discuss regarding the nuclear issue? We are ready to talk again, within the NPT and international principles.